Lesson 7.2: Niyyah, Takbīrat ul-Iḥrām, and Qiyām

Niyyah

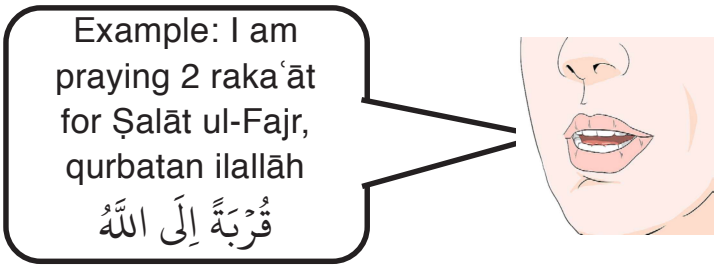
Niyyah is the first among the wājibāt of ṣalāh. It is also a rukn. Niyyah means the intention to do something. Niyyah is important because Islam does not want you to pray just as a habit or an empty ritual; it wants you to be aware of what you do. Before starting ṣalāh and while praying, you must be aware of what you are doing.

The niyyah of prayer must be associated with the idea that you are performing ṣalāh in obedience to the command of Allah, or to seek the pleasure of Allah. Sincerity is the main condition. Your intention should not be mixed with any other purpose, like impressing others; otherwise, your prayer will become incorrect. Remember that your intention must be maintained during the entire ṣalāh. Finally, you must be aware of the ṣalāh which you intend to offer.

In short, three things are important in niyyah:

1. You must know which ṣalāh you intend to offer
2. The intention must be qurbatan ilallāh (sincerely for pleasing and becoming closer to Allah)
3. The intention must be maintained until the end of your ṣalāh

It is not necessary to say anything in order to have a correct niyyah, because a niyyah is a state of mind and heart where you know what you are doing.



Wājibāt of Niyyah:

Niyyah is a rukn of ṣalāh — if you miss it, whether intentionally or by mistake, your ṣalāh will become bāṭil (invalid).

Takbīrat ul-Iḥrām

The second wājib act of ṣalāh is takbīrat ul-iḥrām.

The term takbīrat ul-iḥrām is made from two words: takbīr and iḥrām. Takbīr means to glorify Allah by saying “Allāhu Akbar.” Iḥrām means an act that makes certain things ḥarām. The “Allāhu Akbar” that begins the ṣalāh is known as takbīrat ul-iḥrām because once you say it, you have entered ṣalāh, so the things that break your ṣalāh have now become ḥarām for you. Now, you should not do anything other than ṣalāh — you cannot talk, walk around, eat, purposely turn away from the qiblah, etc.

There are some conditions for takbīrat ul-iḥrām to be correct:

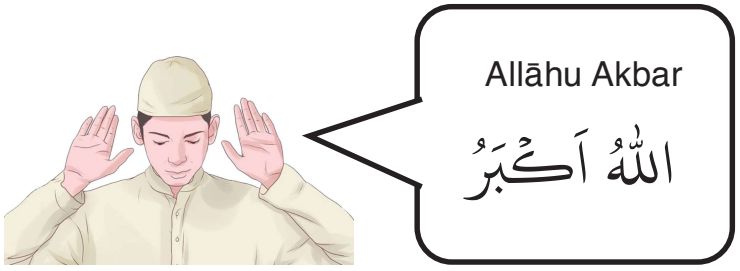
1. It must be pronounced in correct Arabic: Allāhu Akbar.
2. It must be said while standing (unless you are unable to stand), and your body must be motionless.
3. It should be recited without a long gap between the two words.

Lesson 7.2 (con't)

Remember that takbīrat ul-iḥrām is also a rukn of ṣalāh — if you miss it whether intentionally or by mistake, your ṣalāh will become bāṭil.

Rules & Wājibāt of Takbīrat ul-Iḥrām

1. As you already know, takbīrat ul-iḥrām is a rukn. If you add another one intentionally, then your ṣalāh will become bāṭil. So if you say a second "Allāhu Akbar" with the intention of doing a second takbīrat ul-iḥrām after a valid first takbīrat ul-iḥrām, you will have to start all over again.
2. It is better to say the takbīrat ul-iḥrām while you are raising your hands up toward the ears, for your fingers to be closed together, and your palms to be facing the qiblah.

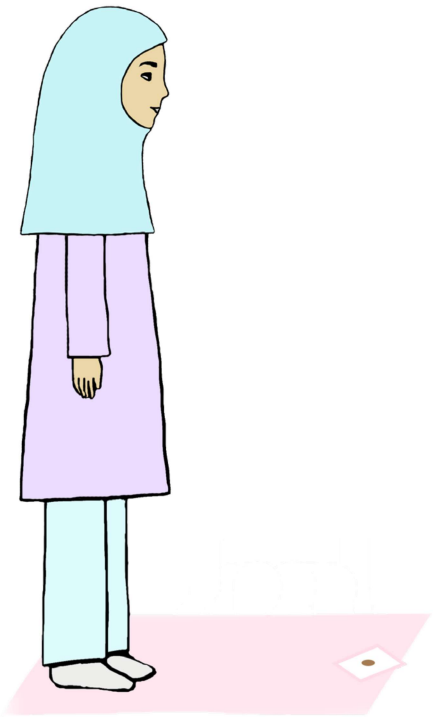


Qiyām

Qiyām means standing. There are qiyāms at different stages of ṣalāh, and not all the qiyāms are equal — some are rukn and some are ghayr rukn. The qiyām immediately before rukūʿ and the qiyām while performing the takbīrat ul-iḥrām are rukn, and if you miss them for some reason, your ṣalāh will be bāṭil.

The Wājibāt and Mustaḥabāt of Qiyām

1. You should stand straight, facing the qiblah.You should stand still, not moving. That is, your body (other than your arms) must be motionless during qiyām.
2. You should not lean on anything while standing (unless you have to).
3. It is mustaḥab for men to stand with their feet 3-5 spread fingers apart and for women to stand with their feet close to each other.
4. It is mustaḥab to let the hands rest on the thighs. It is ḥarām to fold the arms near the waist.



Lesson 7.3: Rukūʿ and Sajdah

Rukūʿ

Rukūʿ is also one of the rukn actions of ṣalāh. If a rukūʿ is left out by mistake or intentionally, your ṣalāh becomes bāṭil.

The Wājibāt of Rukūʿ

It is wājib to bow down in rukūʿ, but, how much should a person bow down?

- It is necessary to at least bow low enough so that you are able to place the tips of all your fingers (including your thumbs) on your knees.
- It is recommended that men bend in such a way that their knees have been pushed backwards, their backs are parallel to the ground, and their palms clasp their knees with their fingers spread apart.
- On the other hand, it is recommended for women to bend somewhat, but not so much that their knees have been pushed backwards, and to rest their hands upon the thighs.

Dhikr of Rukūʿ

The recitation during qiyām is known as qirāʾah, whereas the recitation during rukūʿ is known as dhikr. The dhikr must be in Arabic, and it should be recited in a continuous flow.

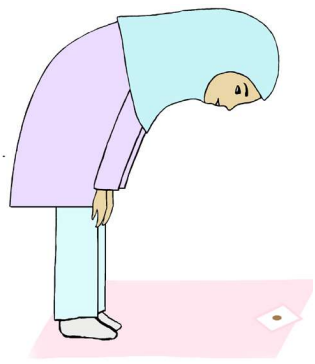
The dhikr of rukūʿ can be:

سُبْحَانَ رَبِّيَ ٱلْعَظِيمِ وَ بِحَمْدِهِ

Subḥāna rabbiyal-ʿaẓīmi wa biḥamdih
Glory and praise be to my Lord, the Supreme

You can also recite the other dhikrs mentioned below.

While reciting the dhikr of rukūʿ, you should be still and not move. You should not start the dhikr until you have reached the actual rukūʿ position and are stable. Of course, if remaining still is not possible because of illness, then it is not wājib. It is also wājib to stand up straight after rukūʿ before performing sajdah.





Examples of Dhikrs

- Subḥānallāh - 3 times
- Subḥāna rabbiyal-ʿaẓīmi wa biḥamdih - 1 time
- Alḥamdulillāh - 3 times
- Allāhu Akbar - 3 times

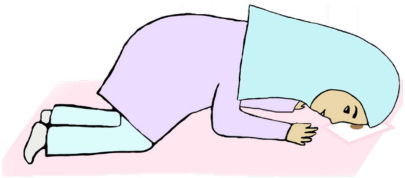
It is mustaḥab to recite ṣalawāt before or after the dhikr

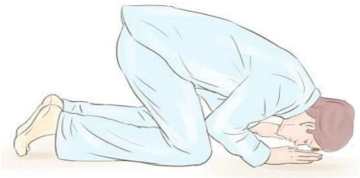
Lesson 7.3 (con't)

Wājibāt of Sajdah

Two sajdahs (sajdatayn) are wājib in every rakʿah of ṣalāh. Together, the two sajdahs are counted as one rukn of ṣalāh. The following are some rules about sajdah:

- If you miss both sajdahs or add two more — whether intentionally or by mistake — your ṣalāh is bāṭil (invalid).
- If you miss only one sajdah or add only one sajdah by mistake, then your ṣalāh is still correct. However, you may need to do a special sajdah after the ṣalāh.
- Adding or missing even one sajdah intentionally will make your ṣalāh bāṭil.
- During sajdah, seven parts of your body must touch the ground: the forehead, two hands (completely, including palms and fingers), two knees, and big toes of both feet.
- The seven body parts must be on the ground during the entire sajdah. If, for some reason, you have to lift any off those parts other than the forehead from the ground, the opinion of some of the marājiʿ is that you can do so only if you pause your recitation and continue the dhikr after you have placed that part on the ground again. The forehead can't be lifted from the ground at all during sajdah. If you do lift it intentionally before completing the dhikr, your ṣalāh will be bāṭil.
- The place on the ground where the forehead is must be on the same level as the toes. If there is any difference, it should not be more than the height of four fingers stacked together (about 3 inches).





Dhikr

Dhikr is also wājib in sajdah. The dhikr of sajdah is similar (but not the same) as rukūʿ. It can be the following:

سُبْحَانَ رَبِّيَ الْأَعْلَىٰ وَ بِحَمْدِهِ

Subḥāna rabbiyal-aʿlā wa biḥamdih
Glory and praise be to my Lord, the High

You may also recite one of the other dhikrs mentioned below.

Examples of Dhikrs

- Subḥānallāh - 3 times
- Subḥāna rabbiyal-aʿlā wa biḥamdih - 1 time
- Alḥamdulillāh - 3 times
- Allāhu Akbar - 3 times

It is mustaḥab to recite ṣalawāt before or after the dhikr